

Communication Reflection: Making the Call Clear

I tend to communicate in a direct, task-focused way. This can help a team move quickly, but I sometimes mistake brevity for clarity. When a goal makes sense to me, I may assume others share the same context. Paul's trumpet analogy in 1 Corinthians 14:8–9 challenges that assumption: a message is useful only when people understand the call and know how to respond. As a leader, I must make the purpose, expectations, and next steps clear.

For this reflection, I considered an instructor-authorized hypothetical machine-learning group project. I was coordinating a team preparing a dataset and training a baseline model. I posted, "Please finish preprocessing and run the baseline model by Thursday." I did not assign an owner, identify the dataset version, define the preprocessing steps, or state whether the work was due before Thursday's meeting.

One teammate cleaned the newest raw dataset, while another trained the model with an older normalized file. A third teammate assumed preprocessing belonged to someone else and waited. At the meeting, the metrics could not be compared because the models had used different data. We spent our time tracing the mismatch and repeating work. This caused frustration because each person believed the instruction had been followed correctly.

My first reaction in that situation might be to wonder why the team had not asked questions. Critical reflection shifts the responsibility back toward my communication. The teammates did not ignore a clear plan; they filled gaps that I had left open. Genesis 11:6–7 shows how a group's progress can stop when shared understanding disappears. The team in this scenario still shared a goal, but the lack of common language about ownership, inputs, and deadlines prevented coordinated action.

To communicate more effectively, I would begin important messages with the purpose of the task and its connection to the team's goal. I would name the owner, specify the dataset and expected output, define what "finished" means, and give an exact deadline. I would also ask each person to restate their responsibility in their own words. This is not a test; it is a way to discover different interpretations before they become errors. After meetings, I would send a short written recap and schedule a check-in for work with several dependencies.

Clear communication also requires humility. If people misunderstand me, I should examine the message before blaming the listener. The trumpet must sound a clear call, and a team needs shared meaning to remain united. By combining specific instructions with questions, confirmation, and follow-up, I can help people understand both what they need to do and why their work matters.

AI-Use Disclosure

At my instructor's direction, I used an AI assistant to create the hypothetical incident and organize this response. The scenario is clearly identified as hypothetical and is not presented as an event that actually occurred.